

THE DROWNED WORLD

PLAYER'S GUIDE



The Tree fell. The sea rose. The world you know is harbors, hulls, and the water between.

A few pages of lore, one character, one ship. That's all it takes to start.



FOR PLAYERS · VERSION 1.1 · SALT-YEAR 312

Start Here

This is everything you need to sit at my table. Read the lore, pick a banner, build your character, and skim the back half so the systems sound familiar when I walk you through them at session zero.

CONTENTS

THE WORLD THAT DROWNED	3
THE SIX BANNERS	5
MAKING YOUR CHARACTER	7
BACKGROUNDS OF THE DROWNED WORLD	8
SPECIES	9
CLASSES	10
RECOMMENDED CLASSES AND SUBCLASSES ..	11

SAILING, VOTING, AND YOUR SHIP	12
MONEY, GUNS, AND BOWS	13
BETWEEN TIDES: THE DOWNTIME GAME	14
THE CHART AND THE HARBORS	15
QUICK REFERENCE	16
2014 TO 2024: WHAT CHANGED	17

THE SHORT VERSION

Pick any species. Pick any class from the allowed books. Pick a faction or stay unsworn. Start at level 1, point buy. You and the rest of the table share one ship, vote on every route, and chase fortune across a drowned world. That's the game.

PART I

The World That Drowned

In the elder days there stood a single Tree, its roots in the deep and its crown holding up the sky, and so long as it stood the waters kept their bounds. Then the Tree fell.

THE CODEX, FIRST PAGE, EVERY COPY

The Elder Days

No living person remembers the world before the water, and that is the first thing to understand about everyone you will ever meet. The elder days are three centuries gone, preserved in salvaged books, drowned architecture, grandmothers' grandmothers' songs, and the stubborn opinions of elves. What is broadly agreed: there was dry land, in quantities now hard to imagine. There were many nations, and they are all dead. And at the center of everything stood the World Tree, a living pillar so vast that its roots drank the deep ocean and its crown carried the floor of heaven. The Tree was not worshipped, exactly. It was relied upon, the way one relies on the ground. Its trunk was the road by which the gods reached their faithful and the road by which the dead climbed out of the world to their rest. Every religion disagreed about everything except the Tree, because the Tree was not a belief. It was infrastructure.

The Fall

Three hundred and twelve years ago, by the reckoning now used in every harbor, the Tree fell. Not withered, not burned: *fell*, in the course of a single day and night, the way a tower falls. It broke the back of the world. The sea rose up in mountains and walked across creation, and what had been is no more. The trunk now lies across thousands of miles of open water like the corpse of a god, its crown still green in places and crowded with survivors, its roots upturned into a grey weeping tangle where the water runs cold, its great branches plunging into and out of the sea to make the only fixed geography the world has left.

Nobody knows why it fell. Every faction in Part 2 is, at heart, a different answer to that question. The elves say the gods of sea and lowland conspired. The Faithful say it was a summons, a divine revolution mistaken for a catastrophe. The Soaring Folk say structures fail and theology is grief wearing a costume. The Faithless say it does not matter why the wave came, only who is still swimming. Three centuries on, the argument has hardened into nations.

The Three Wounds

The drowning was the visible catastrophe. Three quieter ones came with it, and they shape daily life far more than the water does.

THE ROAD OF THE GODS IS BROKEN

The Tree carried prayer up and providence down. With it shattered, the gods are not gone but *distant*, heard the way one hears a voice through a hull. Divine magic still works, but it arrives brackish: clerics describe pulling power through dark water, hand over hand. The sea gods, whose domains were always down here, now answer loudest of all, which is why their priesthoods flourish while older faiths thin out. No god has walked or clearly spoken since the Fall.

THE DEAD DO NOT STAY DROWNED

The Tree was also the road of the dead, and the dead now have nowhere to go. Wherever they lie, sooner or later, they rise: not as an army with a general, but as a condition of the world, like weather. Most risen are slow, sad, and dangerous in the dark; a few remember enough of themselves to be far worse. Every culture has built customs around this. The Boughs entomb their dead in living wood and sing them quiet. The Faithful raise theirs deliberately as labor and call it mercy. The Soaring Folk burn their fallen in the forge furnaces to deny the water a corpse. The Faithless long ago stopped checking. In this world, a funeral is a security measure. Take funerals seriously.

THE HEAVENS SPILLED THEIR SERVANTS

When the road broke, the angels who walked it fell with the waters, stranded on the wrong side of the wound. They are real, they are scattered, they grieve, and they are terrifying: a being built to carry a god's voice, with no god on the line. Some have attached themselves to priesthoods that still half-reach their masters. Others wander. Every faction covets them and none can hold them. An angel arriving in a harbor is the setting's equivalent of a warship arriving: the politics reorganize around it within the hour.

The World as It Lies

Think of the setting vertically. There are five storeys, and sooner or later you will see all of them.

The Crown. The fallen Tree's living canopy, miles of habitable green held above the spray. The elves of the

Boughs keep their last halls here, centered on Hearthbough, the safest harbor in the world and the most suspicious of it.

The Open Sky. The Soaring Folk took to the air rather than sink or cling: zeppelin convoys, dock-platforms lashed to snapped branches, a volcanic forge-isle. Theirs is the only economy that moves faster than weather.

The Shattered Sea. The surface itself: raft-cities, wreck-fields, trade lanes, fog. This is where you live day to day, and where your vessel earns its keep. Law is harbor-by-harbor. Between harbors there is only seamanship, reputation, and powder.

The Deep Roads. Below the light lie the Sunken Realms: coral courts, trench-kingdoms, drowned cities of the old world, and the great luminous branch called the Sunken Bough that serves as a highway for those who can breathe it or hold their nerve.

The Old Dark. Beneath everything, the abyss, where the water swallows light and something enormous sleeps coiled at the heart of the great whirlpool. The Maelstrom Gate is the threshold storm before it. Sailors do not go there.

Salt-Time

Harbors keep the **Salt-Year**, counted from the Fall; we begin in Salt-Year 312. The week is organized around the **Tide**, the slow world-pulse that every port feels and every almanac argues about. The day is kept in bells, ship-fashion. And once, eleven years ago, **the tide ran backward**. One night only. Water drew away from every shore at once, as if the sea had inhaled, and returned by morning wearing an expression nobody could read. Wrecks surfaced that had no business surfacing. Old sailors mention it, then change the subject. A bell somewhere below began ringing that same night, and it has not stopped.

THINGS EVERY SAILOR KNOWS

Dry powder is wealth. The Brine Bazaar truce holds until it doesn't. Funerals are security. Never call the whirlpool by a name, any name. And if you hear a bell at slack tide with no tower in sight, note the hour, say nothing, and sail on.

PART 2

The Six Banners

Factions in the Drowned World are not teams; they are answers to the Fall. Each one is a complete, defensible reading of the same catastrophe, and every one of them is sometimes right. Swearing to a banner gets you +1 reputation with that faction and a named contact inside it. Staying unsworn gets you a contact anywhere and the freedom of owing nobody. No banner locks your species or class, and oaths are choices, not cages: reputation moves with what you do, not what you swore.

THE BOUGHS

Survivors of many elven kindreds, driven together onto the fallen Tree's living crown, where they keep the last green halls in the world. Their priests name the sea gods, and the gods of men and dwarves besides, as the authors of the drowning, so they keep their gates barred and their bows strung. They claim the whole drowned country by right of grief, which makes every welcome at Hearthbough provisional and every outsider a guest on sufferance. Yet they are the world's living memory and its finest archers and herbalists, and a friend among the Boughs is a friend whose word outlasts weather.

AT A GLANCE

Make-up: elves of many kindreds; priests and wardens. **Holdings:** Hearthbough, the living crown. **Outlook:** suspicious of all outsiders; blame the sea and the lowland gods for the Fall. **They want:** the Tree's remnant protected, the guilty named, the old graces remembered. **They fear:** the crown dying branch by branch while the world watches.

THE FAITHFUL

Bloodthirsty and devout, the sea-folk priesthoods hold the Tree's fall as a divine summons, a revolution mistaken for a ruin. They inherited all magic save the working of metal, and each congregation gives worship to a single sea god, vowing to reshape the world into that god's image, which is why the Faithful war as fiercely within their faith as outside it. The sea giants walk among them as living temples and warlords, and at Umberlee's Reach the water itself bends around the spiral coral sanctum and is called holy for it. They are warm to converts, merciless to doubters, and their blessings always cost more than coin.

AT A GLANCE

Make-up: sea-folk casters and priests; sea giants as warlords. **Holdings:** Umberlee's Reach. **Outlook:** the drowning was revolution, not ruin; every god dreams a different new world. **They want:** the world remade god by god, congregation by congregation. **They fear:** silence on the line; a god who stops answering.

THE SOARING FOLK

Engineers, artificers, and smiths, dwarves and gnomes and goblins and humans together, who rose into the open air rather than sink or cling. They dwell in zeppelins and soaring engines and dock-platforms lashed to snapped branches, trusting steel where others trust prayer, and their forges on the Ashen Atoll arm half the world. Nothing among them is given and everything is priced, but a price, unlike a god or a grudge, can always be negotiated. Their dwarves have already turned their craft downward toward deep diving and undersea mining, which the Sunken Realms have noticed, and have opinions about.

AT A GLANCE

Make-up: dwarves, gnomes, goblins, humans; artificers, smiths, pilots. **Holdings:** the Skyhook, the Ashen Atoll, the Brine Bazaar, the Far Mooring. **Outlook:** trust steel over prayer; no part of the world should stay closed to their making. **They want:** fuel, salvage rights, open routes, the deep pried open next. **They fear:** the sky becoming as contested as the sea.

☞ THE FAITHLESS

Those who believe in nothing but the next dawn, driven by hunger, bloodlust, and the savage love of their own kin. They scavenge, burn, and enslave, striking bargains with the newly risen sea devils and pillaging hull and hall to keep their ships fed. They keep no god and no oath but survival, and family is the only loyalty that counts among the beached hulls of the Gravewater Lanes. Yet they are honest in the one way no one else is, for a Faithless raider will never pretend the knife is a sacrament, and the wreck-pickers of Tidewrack remember kindnesses with a fierceness that surprises everyone, including themselves.

AT A GLANCE

Make-up: raiders, scavengers, and slavers; allied sea devils.
Holdings: Gravewater Lanes, Tidewrack Shallows.
Outlook: family is the only loyalty; survival is the only law.
They want: cargo, crews, and to never again be the ones drowning. **They fear:** a winter with no wrecks.

⚓ THE SUNKEN REALMS

Not one people but a thousand: scaled lords, coral courts, trench-kings, and things from realms beyond knowing, all dwelling in the drowned dark. They owe fealty to none above the water and war as often among themselves as with the surface, so that to the dry world they are rumor and shadow with a postal address. Their territory holds most of what the old world left behind, which makes them gatekeepers of salvage, lore, and the Deep Roads that connect everything below the light. To be received at the Deep Court is an honor; to offend there is a sentence.

AT A GLANCE

Make-up: merfolk, tritons, sea hobgoblins (koalinths); aboleths and coral lords. **Holdings:** the Weeping Roots, the Drowned Spire, the Sunken Bough, the Deep Court.
Outlook: loyal to none above the waves; ancient, proud, bitterly divided. **They want:** precedence, protocol, and the surface to remember it is a guest down here. **They fear:** the oldest things among them, who remember the world before the gods and are patient.

☞ THE KRAKEN

It served no god in the elder days and it serves none now. When the Tree fell it woke, and it has moved through the drowned world ever since like a second, slower catastrophe, keeping no faction, answering no prayer, honoring no bargain. Doomsday cults gather at the Maelstrom Gate to worship the fact of it, but the Kraken does not know they exist, which is the whole theology. The only article of faith shared across the entire broken world is the hope that it is still sleeping.

AT A GLANCE

Make-up: the Kraken alone; its cults are drawn from every people. **Holdings:** the Maelstrom Gate, the Sleeping Coil.
Outlook: bound to no one; to be noticed by it is to be already lost. **Swearing this banner** means joining the cult, which is fanatic, well informed, and unwelcome in every harbor. If this is your pick, talk to me privately first.

✦ THE STRANDED HOST (not joinable)

The angels of the broken road, fallen with the waters and stranded on the wrong side of the wound. Some lend their dread radiance to priesthoods that still half-reach their masters; others wander unbound, grieving and terrible, a blade of the heavens looking for a hand. You cannot swear to them, but aasimar carry their blood, and meeting one is the kind of day you tell your grandchildren about, if you get to have grandchildren.

‡ THE DROWNED (nobody's banner)

The risen dead of every people: drowned soldiery, ghost crews, grasping things in the dark, wearing the faces of those who mourned them. They hold no land because they surface everywhere, and they are the one enemy every harbor in the world agrees about.

FACTION RELATIONS IN ONE BREATH

The Boughs blame the Faithful's gods and barely tolerate the Soaring Folk's saws. The Faithful pity the Boughs, buy from the Soaring Folk, and excommunicate each other. The Soaring Folk sell to everyone and are trusted by no one with a theology. The Faithless raid whoever is slow and trade with whoever is rich. The Sunken Realms consider the entire surface a noisy upstairs neighbor. The Host belongs to no one. The Kraken is coming. The Drowned are already here.

PART 3

Making Your Character

1. **The rules.** We're using D&D One, the 2024 rules (some sites call it 5.5e). You start at **level 1** and we're doing **point buy**.
2. **Pick a species.** Any species from the allowed books. None are locked to a faction. Part 5 shows where each people usually lives; one sentence of backstory beats the table.
3. **Pick a class.** Any of the thirteen. Part 6 has what each one means in this world, and Part 7 has the subclasses I think you'll love here. Both Gunslingers (the Mage Hand Press class and Mercer's fighter subclass) are open and I'm buying them, so just ask.
4. **Pick a background.** Any allowed background, reflavored to salt, or grab one of mine in Part 4, or build your own on the same form.
5. **Pick your first loyalty.** One of the six banners (+1 reputation and a contact inside it) or unsworn (a contact anywhere, no debts). Match it to the oath you took in the app.
6. **Answer three questions.** A name you lost to the water. What you believe felled the Tree (it doesn't have to be

true). And, with the whole table: what does our ship mean to us?

7. **Buy gear.** Standard starting equipment and prices. Read Part 9 before you buy a gun. Seriously.

ALLOWED BOOKS

Always open: Player's Handbook (2024). **Open:** Tasha's Cauldron of Everything, Xanathar's Guide to Everything, Monsters of the Multiverse (species), Ghosts of Saltmarsh (backgrounds). **Third party:** the Gunslinger class (Mage Hand Press), the Gunslinger fighter subclass (Matt Mercer), and Oath of the Open Sea, by name. Anything else: pitch me before you build, not after.

BANNED OR BENCHED

No modern or sci-fi weapons of any kind. No lasers (someone asked). Nothing that trivializes water at level 1, so no unlimited water breathing out of the gate. Playing a flying species? Talk to me and we'll work out a soft start; the sky belongs to vehicles for a few levels.

PART 4

Backgrounds of the Drowned World

A 2024 background is five choices: **three ability scores** (you'll put a +2 and a +1 among them, or +1 to all three), **one origin feat**, **two skill proficiencies**, **one tool proficiency**, and **starting equipment** (the listed package or 50 gp). The four below fill every blank and come with a hook. If you build your own on this form, run it past me and it's in.

WRECK-DIVER

You went down where the old world sleeps and came back up with its pockets.

Ability Scores: Strength, Dexterity, Constitution

Feat: Tough

Skill Proficiencies: Athletics, Investigation

Tool Proficiency: Cartographer's tools

Equipment: Crowbar, 50 feet of silk rope, waxed satchel, grease-lamp with 3 flasks of oil, a dive-slate and chalk, traveler's clothes, 8 gp; or 50 gp

Hook: you keep one thing you brought up that you have never shown anyone. Decide what it is with me.

ATOLL FORGE-HAND

You sweated in the Ashen Atoll's furnace-halls, where half the world's steel is born and all of its gossip passes through.

Ability Scores: Strength, Constitution, Intelligence

Feat: Crafter

Skill Proficiencies: Athletics, Insight

Tool Proficiency: Smith's tools

Equipment: Smith's tools, leather apron, hammer, a bar of good iron, ear-wax plugs, a furnace-scarred letter of work, traveler's clothes, 12 gp; or 50 gp

Hook: a weapon you forged is out there doing something you're not proud of. You'd know the strike-mark anywhere.

POWDER RUNNER

Dry powder is wealth that can argue, and you moved it quietly between harbors that were not supposed to have it.

Ability Scores: Dexterity, Intelligence, Charisma

Feat: Alert

Skill Proficiencies: Deception, Sleight of Hand

Tool Proficiency: Navigator's tools

Equipment: Navigator's tools, waxed powder horn (empty), false-bottomed crate, set of forged dock papers, dark common clothes, 15 gp; or 50 gp

Hook: one delivery never arrived, and two different factions believe you still have it.

TIDE-CLAN KIN

You were raised on a raider deck in the Gravewater Lanes, where family is the only loyalty and the sea takes the slow.

Ability Scores: Strength, Dexterity, Charisma

Feat: Tavern Brawler

Skill Proficiencies: Intimidation, Survival

Tool Proficiency: Vehicles (water)

Equipment: Belaying pin (club), grappling hook, clan-knot bracelet, oilskin cloak, a share-token from your last raid, common clothes, 10 gp; or 50 gp

Hook: you left the clan, or the clan left you. Either way, somebody back there says you still owe a share.

ROLLING YOUR OWN

Pick the three abilities your story trained, the origin feat it earned, two skills, one tool, and a pocketful of gear that smells like your past. Then give me one hook: a debt, a grudge, a secret, or a name. The hook is the price of admission, and it's how your background keeps paying you back all campaign.

PART 5

Species

Species	Usually found	In this world
Human	Everywhere	The sea's common coin. Humans crew everything, believe everything, and are the majority in every harbor that isn't somebody's homeland.
Elf	Boughs	Many kindreds folded into one grieving nation on the crown. Sea elves are the exception: most swam to the Sunken Realms generations ago, a defection Hearthbough has not forgiven.
Dwarf	Soaring Folk	Mountainless and unbothered: a forge floats fine. Atoll smiths, and the pioneers of deep diving and undersea mining, to the Sunken Realms' growing irritation.
Gnome	Soaring Folk	Zeppelin engineers, instrument-makers, and the people who actually read the pressure gauges.
Goblin	Soaring Folk, Faithless	Founding crew of the airdocks: riggers, scrap-sorters, powder monkeys. Clans that never got a berth turned raider instead.
Halfling	Unsworn, Soaring Folk	Raft-folk and bazaar-keepers. Halfling family barges are the closest thing the sea has to neutral ground, and everyone owes one of them money.
Orc	Faithless, Soaring Folk	The Fall hit orc nations hardest and made them the sea's great survivors. Tide-clans dominate the raider lanes, while orc salvage-divers and forge-hands are prized labor among the Soaring Folk. An orc handshake outranks most contracts.
Dragonborn	Faithful, Sunken Realms	Held to descend from the sea-wyrms of the elder deep. Congregations compete to recruit them; the Deep Court seats them above most surface envoys.
Tiefling	Faithless, unsworn	The brine-touched: fiend-marked lines the old world exiled to the coasts, which means they were already sailors when the wave came. Superstition follows them; so does grudging respect.
Aasimar	Unsworn, Faithful	Descendants and echoes of the Stranded Host. Every harbor wants one as a figurehead; few aasimar enjoy being a relic of a severed heaven.
Goliath	Faithful, Faithless	Storm-giant and sea-giant blood. The Faithful treat them as half-holy; raider crews treat them as artillery.
Triton, sea elf, merfolk	Sunken Realms	The deep's nobility and commons. The ones walking the surface are envoys, exiles, or the curious.
Koalinth	Sunken Realms	Sea hobgoblins: the Deep Court's legions, disciplined, contract-bound, and entirely unimpressed by surface armies.
Lizardfolk, turtle	Unsworn, Sunken Realms	The amphibious middle class. Turtle pilots are the finest shallow-water guides alive, and they know it.
Aarakocra, owlin, kenku	Soaring Folk	The winged folk found their century. Kenku, flightless and sharp-eared, run the airdocks' signals, gossip, and less official messaging.
Tabaxi	Unsworn, Soaring Folk	Rigging-runners and far-traders, collecting harbors the way other people collect coins. The best topmen afloat.
Genasi	By element	Water genasi to the Faithful and the Sunken; air genasi to the Soaring Folk; fire genasi to the Atoll forges. Earth genasi are rare enough to be an event.
Firbolg	Boughs	Quiet giants of the crown's deep galleries, tending what green remains. The Boughs trust them further than they trust most elves.
Half-orc, half-elf	As either parent	Three centuries of shared decks. Common everywhere, remarked on nowhere.
Warforged (ask me)	Soaring Folk	Pre-Fall engines that woke up. Each one is a walking archaeological dispute. I approve these individually.

PART 6

Classes

Class	In the Drowned World
Artificer	The Soaring Folk's pride. Infusions read as riveted, soldered, and slightly overdue for inspection. The class most likely to be poached by every harbor it docks in.
Barbarian	Storm-readers and boarding-action royalty. Faithless tide-clans and goliath wave-callers; Rage often reads as the sea getting into someone.
Bard	The world's archive and its postal service. Songs are how drowned history survives; a bard's repertoire is literally salvage.
Cleric	Divine power arrives brackish, hauled hand over hand through dark water since the road broke. Sea-god clerics hear best; older faiths whisper. Pick your god, then pick which congregation of that god, because they are feuding.
Druid	Keepers of what green and wild remains. Bough circles tend the crown; sea druids speak for reefs and currents. Wild Shape into something with gills early and often.
Fighter	Marines, harpooners, duelists of the dock. Mercer's Gunslinger subclass lives here; so does every archer who will outshoot any gun in the rain.
Gunslinger (Mage Hand Press)	The flintlock as a calling, not a sidearm: trick shots, iron nerve, and powder discipline, with Risk Dice for the moments that decide everything. Spellslingers thread magic through the barrel, which in this world raises questions worth playing.
Monk	Breath is doctrine. Sunken breath-hold schools, Bough stillness orders, and dock-fighting traditions that treat a rolling deck as a training advantage.
Paladin	The oath is the power, and the broken road cannot touch it; paladins are walking proof that conviction needs no infrastructure. Each faction fields its own oath flavor.
Ranger	Pilots, channel-readers, wreck-guides. Favored terrain is a tide table. The most employable class on the Shattered Sea.
Rogue	Smugglers, salvage lawyers, and the Brine Bazaar's entire middle management. Half this campaign's problems are locked, and the other half are guarded.
Sorcerer	The Fall left marks in bloodlines: storm-touched, deep-touched, tree-marked. A sorcerer is a place where the catastrophe is still happening, politely.
Warlock	The growth class of the age. Patrons answer faster than gods now: sea powers, things of the Deep Court, a stranded angel, or something at the bottom of the world that should not be flattered with worship. Know exactly who holds your line.
Wizard	Old-world scholarship, dived for page by page. Spellbooks are salvage; rival wizards are rival archaeologists; the Drowned Spire is the career destination.

PART 7

Recommended Classes and Subclasses

Pick	Class
Gunslinger	Full class (Mage Hand Press)
Spellslinger	Gunslinger (Mage Hand Press)
Gunslinger	Fighter (Matt Mercer)
Rune Knight	Fighter
Psi Warrior	Fighter
Path of the World Tree	Barbarian
Path of the Storm Herald	Barbarian
Path of the Zealot	Barbarian
Circle of the Sea	Druid
Circle of the Land (Coastal)	Druid
Circle of Stars	Druid
Tempest Domain	Cleric
Twilight Domain	Cleric
The Fathomless	Warlock
The Genie (Marid)	Warlock
Great Old One	Warlock
The Celestial	Warlock
Storm Sorcery	Sorcerer
Aberrant Mind	Sorcerer
Clockwork Soul	Sorcerer
Oath of the Open Sea	Paladin
Oath of the Ancients	Paladin
Warrior of the Elements	Monk
Way of Mercy	Monk
Swashbuckler	Rogue
Phantom	Rogue
Soulknife	Rogue
Armorer	Artificer
Battle Smith	Artificer
Swarmkeeper	Ranger
Gloom Stalker	Ranger
Fey Wanderer	Ranger
College of Glamour	Bard
College of Dance	Bard

These are suggestions I highly recommend, but anything from the core and companion manuals is allowed.

PART 8

Sailing, Voting, and Your Ship

Between adventures, the campaign moves harbor to harbor on the chart (Part 11). Every leg works the same way, and the app runs the numbers live on the screen.

1. **See your options.** Each route from your current harbor shows who controls it, its DC, what you gain if the crossing goes well, what it always costs, and what it costs if it goes badly.
2. **Vote.** Everyone taps a route. Majority sails. The captain breaks ties.
3. **One roll.** d20, plus the party's reputation with the route's controlling faction, plus a boon if you spend one, minus the supply penalty if the hold is lean. Beat the DC.
4. **Land on the tide.** Every arrival comes with a harbor event, fair or foul. Sometimes it's free rope. Sometimes a priest reads your wake and doesn't like it.

WHAT MOVES THE ROLL

Reputation with the controlling faction is the modifier, so who you've helped and robbed follows you onto the water. **Supplies below 3** cost you: minus 2 per step down, to minus 6 at empty. **A boon** is a stored favor worth +2 on any one d20, declared before the roll. Spend them like they're real, because someone earned them.

THE VESSEL

- **The craft.** One shared vessel: a Ship (tough and armed), a Zeppelin (fast and far-seeing), or a Submarine (quiet and deep).
- **Stats.** Hull, Armor, Speed, Maneuver, Firepower, Stealth, Sensors.
- **Upgrades.** Four slots. Tiers cost party Resolve: 2, then 4, then 6.
- **DISABLED.** Each system holds part of the hull's health. A system beaten to zero loses its bonuses until repaired.
- **Table ritual.** In ship combat a natural 20 flashes gold and also hits a system of your choice. A natural 1 thuds, and your gun fouls until the crew clears it.

THE PARTY'S THREE NUMBERS

- **Supplies.** The hold: food, rope, oil, canvas. Keep them at 3 or better or your rolls start paying for it.
- **Resolve.** The crew's nerve, and the currency of ship upgrades.
- **Boons.** Stored +2s, one use each, from gods, deeds, and agents working for you all week (Part 10).

REPUTATION

- **One score per faction** for the whole party: your travel modifier on their routes, your welcome at their docks, and roughly a 5% lean on prices per point.
- **At +4** they hold a berth open for you. **At minus 4**, docking is a tactical decision.

PART 9

Money, Guns, and Bows

COIN

Metal doesn't care whose kingdom drowned, so every price in the books works unchanged. Pre-Fall coin dredged from the deep is called **drowned coin**; it spends at face value and attracts questions, because every old coin implies a dive site. Two things sit beside coin as near-currency: **dry powder**, which is wealth that can argue, and **fresh water** in cask, the politest bribe on the Shattered Sea.

MONEY OF THE SHATTERED SEA

Standard	Local name	Notes
1 cp	bit	Stamped harbor copper; also drilled shell on the raft-lanes.
1 sp	hook	Named for the fishhook punch-mark most mints use.
1 ep	brace	Rare; mostly Sunken Realms court payment. Surface folk distrust it.
1 gp	sovereign	The benchmark. A drowned (pre-Fall) sovereign is worth 1 gp and one raised eyebrow.
1 pp	tree-ring	Bough-minted platinum rounds, rim-carved like growth rings. Ceremonial weight.
Powder, 1 horn (20 shots)	(commodity)	Trades around 10 gp dry, double in remote harbors, ten times that mid-crisis.

FIREARMS

PLAYING A GUNSLINGER?

The Mage Hand Press class and Mercer's fighter subclass each have their own weapon stats and misfire rules; use those for your features. The table below is for everyone else.

Guns exist and they are flintlock, full stop. Nothing newer exists or can be invented. A gun hits hard, costs a fortune to feed, hates weather, and tells everyone within half a mile exactly where you are.

Weapon	Cost	Damage	Range	Misfire
Flintlock pistol	200 gp	1d10 piercing	30/90	1
Sea musket	400 gp	1d12 piercing	40/120	2
Blunderbuss	300 gp	2d6 piercing	15/30	2
Harpoon gun	350 gp	1d10 piercing	30/60	1

All are martial, Loading (one shot per action), and Loud. **Misfire:** roll the listed number or lower on your attack and the gun fouls; clearing it takes an action and a DC 10 tinker's tools check. Rain raises misfire by 1, a storm by 2. Dunk a loaded gun and the powder is ruined; nothing fires underwater. The blunderbuss can shove a close target 5 feet. The harpoon gun trails a 50-foot line and can reel what it hits.

WHY YOU MIGHT STILL TAKE THE BOW

No misfire. No noise. No reload limit, so every attack on your sheet fires. Arrows cost pennies and you get them back. Rain doesn't care. The gun trades all that for a bigger die and a bigger entrance. Both are correct. Pick your personality.

Between Tides: The Downtime Game

Between Tides is your character's life between sessions: working docks, chasing rumors, training, drinking, and crawling delves. It feeds the table game (rumors become session hooks, agents mint boons) but never touches your character sheet. A level 1 stays a level 1 no matter how busy their week was. The riches here are information, standing, trinkets, and story.

CANDLES

You hold up to **3 candles**. One candle buys one undertaking. A spent candle comes back after 8 hours.

THE SEVEN UNDERTAKINGS

Find Rumors: Docks and **Find Rumors: Market** work the waterline and the stalls for hooks. **Chase a Rumor** spends one to run it down; three wins confirms it into something real. **Unwind: Tavern** calms stress in company. **Recover** rests, mends, and clears your head. **Dig for Lore** hits archives and elders. **Personal Goal** is your own project, built with me.

Every undertaking deals you a scene with a careful option and a bold option. Roll the d20, add your skill bar (it grows with use, old-school style) and your equipped trinkets. About a third of wins come with a **press**: double or nothing at minus 3. The Whaleback Die exists for people who can't say no.

STRESS AND WOUNDS

Risk is paid in **stress**, 0 to 10. At 7 you start to fray. At 10 something gives, and you pick up a state of mind: Tide-Maddened, Wary of Every Face, Wreck-Eyed, Hollowed, or, rarely, Sea-Steadied, the one that's a gift. **Wounds** last 3 real days and lock the bold option until they heal. The tavern is cheaper than therapy and riskier than therapy.

DELVES

Six dive sites are open across the chart, room by branching room. **Five failed attempts in one room collapses the run** with everything you haven't carried out. Below the light, every failure also bites the party's stores: 1 Supply, 1 Resolve. You carry six finds, equip two trinkets, and at the bottom of each delve something with a name is waiting, guarding a rare that drops nowhere else. The six: the **Bloated Carrack**, a treasure galleon whose drowned quartermaster kept every thief he caught; the **Drowned Vault**, a flooded bank whose dead clerk audits everything that enters; the **Cult Warren**, tunnels where something with a hundred stolen mouths sings one note; the **Sunken Orchard**, a drowned grove still bearing golden fruit, with a guardian; the **Fallen Skylift**, an airdock whose salvage machines fused into one huge singing thing; and the **Bell-Drowned Chapel**, which sank mid-service, where the dead sexton has rung the bell for eleven years.

CAN'T MAKE GAME NIGHT? BE AN AGENT

Friends and players who can't sit at the table can still play Between Tides as **agents**: their own characters, sworn to a banner. Agent wins fill their faction's collective bar (big things happen at 33, 66, and 100) and build affinity with the table. Every 25 affinity mints a **boon**: a +2 the table can spend on any travel roll. Somewhere out there, someone's Tuesday makes your Saturday roll succeed.

PART II

The Chart and the Harbors



Node color marks the controlling faction. Numbered seals mark each route's DC. West is the wrong direction.

THE FOURTEEN

- **Hearthbough** 🌿 The elves' living crown, the safest harbor in the world and the most suspicious of you.
- **Far Mooring** ⚙️ The last friendly light at the world's eastern edge, trading rumor for supplies.
- **Skyhook** ⚙️ The busiest port in the sky; nothing is given, everything is priced.
- **Ashen Atoll** ⚙️ The volcanic forge-isle that arms half the world.
- **Brine Bazaar** ⚙️ The raft-city market where every faction trades under a truce thinner than the planks.
- **Umberlee's Reach** 🌀 A spiral coral temple where blessings cost more than coin.
- **Weeping Roots** 🌳 The Tree's upturned roots, cold water, and dead that don't always stay drowned.
- **Drowned Spire** 🏰 An old-world tower half-swallowed by the sea; treasure in the deep rooms, and whatever guards it.
- **Sunken Bough** 🌊 A glowing coral road through the deep; guides know the way, strangers vanish.
- **Deep Court** 🏰 The coral palace where the drowned realms hold audience; to offend is a sentence.
- **Gravewater Lanes** ☠️ Fog-bound raider channels where outsiders are cargo or corpses.
- **Tidewrack Shallows** ☠️ A wreck-field endlessly scavenged and never empty; claims are settled with knives.
- **Maelstrom Gate** 🌀 The threshold storm where the sky goes wrong; a warning the world stopped heeding.
- **Sleeping Coil** 🌀 The whirlpool at the heart of the dark. To reach it is the end of most journeys.

PART 1 2

Quick Reference

TRAVEL

Preview routes, vote, captain rolls: d20 + reputation with the route's faction + boon (if spent) – supply penalty, vs DC. Then the harbor's tide event, fair or foul.

SUPPLIES

The hold: food, rope, oil, canvas. 3+ Supplies: fine. 2: minus 2. 1: minus 4. 0: minus 6.

RESOLVE

The crew's nerve, and the currency of ship upgrades: 2, then 4, then 6 per tier. Earned by routes, rest, and victories. Don't let it hit zero.

BOONS

+2 to one d20, declared before the roll, one use, no stacking.

REPUTATION

+4 named friends · +1 to +3 known · 0 strangers · –1 to –3 marked · –4 hunted.

FIREARMS

Pistol 1d10 (misfire 1) · Musket 1d12 (misfire 2) · Blunderbuss 2d6 (misfire 2) · Harpoon gun 1d10 (misfire 1). One shot per action. Loud. Rain +1 misfire, storm +2. Wet powder is dead powder. Powder and shot: 10 gp per 20.

BETWEEN TIDES

3 candles, one back per 8 hours. Stress frays at 7, breaks at 10. Wounds: 3 days, bold locked. Chase: 3 wins confirms a rumor. Delves: 5 fails in a room collapses it; deep failures bite 1 Supply and 1 Resolve; carry 6, equip 2.

MONEY

bit (cp) · hook (sp) · brace (ep) · sovereign (gp) · tree-ring (pp). Drowned coin spends and gets noticed. Powder is wealth that can argue.



The Tree fell. Chris didn't. See you Fridays.

2014 to 2024: What Changed

If you played 2014 fifth edition, this is what's different. Where a 2014 and 2024 version of anything both exist, we use 2024.

BUILDING A CHARACTER

- Ability score bonuses come from your background now, not your species: +2/+1 or +1/+1/+1 among the background's three listed abilities.
- Every background grants an Origin feat at level 1.
- Every class gets its subclass at level 3. No exceptions anymore.
- Feats are tiered: Origin, General (level 4+, each includes a +1 ability score), Fighting Style, and Epic Boon (level 19).

CORE RULES

- Heroic Inspiration: spend it to reroll any die; you must keep the new roll. Humans get it every long rest.
- Weapon Mastery: martial classes unlock an extra property on their weapons (Cleave, Graze, Nick, Push, Sap, Slow, Topple, Vex).
- The action list is standardized: Attack, Dash, Disengage, Dodge, Help, Hide, Influence, Magic, Ready, Search, Study, Utilize.
- Hiding is one rule: DC 15 Dexterity (Stealth); success gives you the Invisible condition until you're found or you break it.
- Surprise no longer skips turns: surprised creatures roll initiative with disadvantage.
- Drinking a potion is a Bonus Action.
- Unarmed Strike can damage, grapple, or shove; grapple and shove are a save against DC 8 + your Strength modifier + proficiency bonus.
- Exhaustion: each level is minus 2 to all D20 Tests and minus 5 feet of Speed; level 6 kills.

CLASS HEADLINES

Class	What changed
Artificer	Not in the 2024 PHB; we use the Tasha's version unchanged.
Barbarian	Rage persists while you attack or take damage and can be extended as a bonus action. Weapon Mastery. Brutal Strikes replace Brutal Critical.
Bard	Subclass at 3. Magical Secrets is built in at level 10 for every bard. Song of Rest is gone.
Cleric	Divine Order choice at level 1 (Protector or Thaumaturge). Channel Divinity at 2 includes Divine Spark. Domain at 3.
Druid	Primal Order choice at level 1. Wild Shape reworked: you keep your own hit points and gain temporary HP, with a list of known forms.
Fighter	The most Weapon Mastery slots. Second Wind has multiple uses and fuels Tactical Mind (add a d10 to a failed ability check).
Monk	Ki is now Focus. Martial Arts starts at a d6. Deflect Attacks works on more than missiles. Stunning Strike is once per turn, with a lesser effect on a successful save.
Paladin	Divine Smite is a spell: a bonus action, once per turn, always prepared. Lay On Hands is a bonus action.
Ranger	Hunter's Mark is the class spine, always prepared with free castings. Favored terrain is gone. Expertise at level 1.
Rogue	Steady Aim at 3. Cunning Strike at 5: trade Sneak Attack dice for trips, poisons, and clean exits.
Sorcerer	Innate Sorcery at 1 (bonus action: +1 spell save DC and advantage on spell attacks). Font of Magic and Metamagic at 2.
Warlock	Patron at 3. Pact of the Blade, Chain, and Tome are now Eldritch Invocations you can pick and swap, and you know more invocations overall.
Wizard	Subclass at 3. Memorize Spell swaps one prepared spell on a short rest.

NEW SUBCLASSES IN THE 2024 PHB

- **Brand new:** Path of the World Tree (Barbarian), College of Dance (Bard), Circle of the Sea (Druid).

Promoted into the core book from expansions:

- Path of the Zealot (Barbarian)
- College of Glamour (Bard)
- Circle of Stars (Druid)
- Psi Warrior (Fighter)
- Warrior of Mercy (Monk)
- Oath of Glory (Paladin)
- Fey Wanderer (Ranger)
- Gloom Stalker (Ranger)
- Soulknife (Rogue)
- Aberrant Sorcery (Sorcerer)
- Clockwork Sorcery (Sorcerer)
- The Celestial (Warlock)

New classes: Tasha's Artificer, Matt Mercer's Gunslinger Fighter subclass, and the Mage Hand Press Gunslinger with these subclasses:

- **Deadeye.** A precise, eagle-eyed marksman.
- **High Roller.** Gambles with their life and fortune; no risk is too high.
- **Secret Agent.** A covert agent with a license to kill.
- **Spellslinger.** Fires spells as well as bullets in deadly bombardments.
- **Trick Shot.** Ricochets bullets to hit targets from any angle.
- **White Hat.** A law-abiding protector of the weak that never blinks in the face of danger.

NEW AND REWORKED SYSTEMS

- **Species rebuilt.** Ability bonuses moved to backgrounds. Humans get an extra Origin feat and Heroic Inspiration every long rest. Aasimar, goliath, and orc are in the core book now. Half-elves and half-orcs are no longer separate entries: pick either parent's species and describe yourself as mixed, which is how our species table already treats them.
- **Crafting is a real system.** With proficiency in the right tool and raw materials worth half an item's price, you can craft equipment during downtime; each tool's PHB entry lists what it can make. Healing potions (herbalism kit) and spell scrolls are explicitly craftable. The Crafting system is going to be managed via Between Tides.
- **Bastions (2024 DMG).** An optional level 5+ home base system with its own turn structure. We are not using it:

the ship is the base and Between Tides is the downtime engine.

SPELLS WORTH REREADING

- All the smites are spells now: bonus action, once per turn.
- Counterspell: the target makes a Constitution save; a countered spell fizzles, but its slot is not expended.
- True Strike is actually good: attack with your weapon using your spellcasting ability, with radiant damage at higher levels.
- Healing spells roll bigger dice across the board (Cure Wounds 2d8, Healing Word 2d4).
- The conjure spells (animals, minor elementals, woodland beings) are completely rebuilt: effects, not stat-block swarms.
- Many staples were rebalanced. If a spell is on your sheet, skim its 2024 text once before session one.